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In-Party Love, Out-Party Hate, and Affective Polarization in Twelve Established Democracies

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Abstract Recent research has mapped levels of affective polarization worldwide. However, our current knowledge of the longitudinal patterns of in- and out-party affect, the two constitutive terms of affective polarization, remains limited. This manuscript expands the comparative and longitudinal scope of existing studies using national election study data from 143 elections across 12 Western democracies collected since the 1960s. The analysis expands previous descriptive accounts of levels of in- and out-party affect, reports levels of in-party love and out-party hate, and inspects longitudinal changes in the polarity of affect with a composite measure tapping the relative weight of in- and out-party feelings. The findings show a generalized decline of out-party evaluations and a growing prevalence of out-party hate versus in-party love over time. While citizens may not be more polarized than before in most Western democracies, contemporary affective polarization is more heavily characterized by a disproportionate weight of out-group dislike.

Recent studies have taken important steps into mapping and longitudinally describing levels of affective polarization in Western democracies (Gidron et al. 2020; Garzia, Ferreira da Silva, and Maye 2023; Boxell, Gentzkow, and Shapiro 2024). Overall, the findings from these studies point to a substantial increase over time in levels of affective polarization in the United States, unparalleled in other democracies.

As a common denominator, existing comparative research tends to measure affective polarization as the absolute distance between in-party affect and out-party (or parties) disdain. However, our current knowledge of the respective longitudinal patterns of these two components is limited.

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Gidron et al. (2020) report levels of in- and out-party affect in twenty Western democracies, across the period 1996–2017. Their analysis shows a "gradual trend of declining in-party liking" (p. 34) as well as "an overall trend of intensifying out-party dislike over the past several years" (p. 31). According to a longitudinal analysis of twelve OECD democracies by Boxell, Gentzkow, and Shapiro (2024), affect toward other parties decreased more strongly in the United States than in any of the other countries under study.

Exploring patterns of in- and out-party affect—as well as their reciprocal relationship—is relevant insofar as it can shed light on the relative importance of the two components in driving affective polarization over time. To address this issue, the authors of a foundational study on political sectarianism in America developed measures of "in-party love" and "out-party hate" by recoding in-party and out-party thermometer scores relative to the middle point of the scale (Finkel et al. 2020). By taking the difference between these two scores, the authors captured the changing relative importance of in-party affect and out-party disdain as drivers of affective polarization. Tracking these measures over four decades of American presidential elections, the authors show that out-party hate has emerged as a stronger force than in-party love for affective polarization in the United States.

Our analysis is aimed at expanding the comparative and longitudinal scope of existing studies. Our pooled national election study dataset includes thermometer evaluations for political parties (and leaders) in 143 elections across 12 Western democracies collected over the last six decades (1961–2022). Our contribution is twofold. First, we expand previous descriptive accounts of levels of in- and out-party affect, as well as in-party love and out-party hate, in comparative and longitudinal perspective. Second, taking advantage of the differential measure developed by Finkel and colleagues, we report the extent to which affective polarization has become increasingly driven by out-party hate in the majority of countries under analysis.

Data and Measurement

Our analysis is based on a novel collection of national election study datasets from Western democracies featuring extended time series of post-electoral survey data worth (at least) five decades. The final sample includes a total of 143 elections from 12 democracies (full details in Supplementary Material table S1).[1,2]

1. Data for the twelve European democracies come from the "West European Voter" harmonization project (Garzia, Ferreira da Silva, and Maye 2023). Information about survey response rates can be consulted in the original surveys' documentation, compiled by the "West European Voter" project at https://cadmus.eui.eu/bitstream/handle/1814/75520/Data%20sources.xlsx?sequence=8&isAllowed=y.

2. No weights have been used in the analyses, and item-missing data have been listwise deleted.

As per standard practice in comparative (and longitudinal) research on affective polarization, we rely on party feeling thermometers as an instrument to capture survey respondents' feelings toward the parties (Gidron et al. 2020; Reiljan 2020; Wagner 2021; Garzia, Ferreira da Silva, and Maye 2023; Boxell, Gentzkow, and Shapiro 2024).[3] To ensure comparability of estimates across countries and elections, all thermometer scores have been rescaled into a 0–10 scale. The original question wording and answer scales are available in Supplementary Material table S2.

Our measures for in- and out-party affect largely draw on preexisting measures of affective polarization for multiparty systems that capture the difference in affect between an in-party and all remaining parties competing in a given election (Wagner 2021; Garzia, Ferreira da Silva, and Maye 2023; Boxell, Gentzkow, and Shapiro 2024). Thus, we follow these studies and define the in-party as the party receiving the highest score among all parties rated by the respondent on the party feeling thermometers.[4] The out-party measure is drawn from the average of all other parties' feeling thermometer scores, weighted by their respective vote shares. Importantly, this procedure replicates the ones used in previous comparative accounts of in-party and out-party affect (Gidron et al. 2020; Boxell, Gentzkow, and Shapiro 2024).

In a second step, following the strategy advanced by Finkel et al. (2020), we present measures of "in-party love" and "out-party hate" by computing

3. Due to the unsystematic presence of party feeling thermometers for the Italian and Spanish election studies, we have calculated the respective scores using leader feeling thermometers instead. Existing comparative research confirms a strong correlation between party- and leader-based measures of affective polarization, particularly in the cases of Italy and Spain (Reiljan et al. 2024). For Spain, the Pearson's correlation between aggregate scores of party (PAP) and leader (LAP) affective polarization is 0.95. For Italy, we are unable to calculate such correlation because only the 2022 Italian Election Study features both party and leader thermometer batteries. However, the individual-level correlation of these two measures is 0.85 with virtually identical mean sample values (PAP = 5.12; LAP = 5.09).

4. To remain agnostic about *which* party should be considered the in-party, we adopted the following procedure whenever a respondent gave the highest score to more than one party. First, we summed up the party vote shares of all most liked parties and divided by the total number of most liked parties. Second, in the out-party calculations, the remaining parties receiving the same score as the most liked party would be weighted by this adjusted party vote share. Hence, for example, if voter X scored Party A with 7 (30 percent party vote share), Party B with 7 (10 percent), Party C with 5 (40 percent), and Party D with 3 (20 percent), their in-party value would be 7, and their out-party would correspond to: 7 x ((0.30 + 0.10)/2) + 5 x 0.40 + 3 x 0.20 = 4. Following Reiljan's (2020) conceptualization, we have replicated the analysis defining the in-party based on self-reported partisanship, and maintaining the out-party affect as the average score given to all other parties, weighted by their respective party vote shares. This analysis excludes respondents who have not declared to identify with any political party and excludes election studies without questions on partisanship. Our results are largely robust to this alternative measurement specification and sample selection (see Supplementary Material figures S1–S3).

the previous measures of in- and out-party affect relative to the neutral point on the feeling thermometer,[5] so that:

- *in-party love = [In-party score—5];*
- *out-party hate = [5—Mean weighted out-party score].*

Finally, we took the difference between those two scores [in-party love—out-party hate] to inspect changes in the polarity of affect in a given country/election, that is, whether affective polarization is predominantly characterized by positive or negative affect. As both the constituent terms of this measure can range between −5 and 5, the difference between them yields a variable ranging from −10 to +10, where above-zero values on this variable reflect greater in-group love than out-group hate, and below-zero values reflect greater out-group hate than in-group love.

Trends

The trends reported from our data generally support Gidron et al.'s (2020) conclusion of a gradual decline of in-party liking (see figure 1). Indeed, the slope of the regression line is negative in eleven out of twelve countries and this relationship reaches conventional levels of statistical significance in Denmark, Germany, Greece, Spain, and the United Kingdom (see Supplementary Material table S3). When it comes to voters' feelings toward out-parties, the picture is once again of a generalized decline. The regression slope is negative in nine out of twelve countries, and reaches conventional levels of statistical significance in Canada, Denmark, Germany, Portugal, Spain, the United Kingdom, and the United States (see Supplementary Material table S3).

To our purposes, it is worth noting that the linear decline of out-party feelings is stronger than the decline of in-party feelings in almost half of the countries under analysis: Canada, Denmark, Italy, Sweden, and the United States (see Supplementary Material table S3).

This unbalance is better captured through a longitudinal assessment of the measures of in-party love and out-party hate (see figure 2). As explained, these are but a mere transformation of the previous measures, allowing us to better compare the relative strength of the two components over time. The emerging pattern confirms an over-time change toward a stronger relative

5. This transformation is based on the notion that the midpoint of the thermometer scale taps neutral feelings toward the attitude object of interest. This is supported by Iyengar and Krupenkin's (2018) analysis of ANES data and by the observation that numerous election studies (including ANES) explicitly instruct respondents to pick the midpoint of the scale whenever they feel indifferent toward a given party (see Supplementary Material table S2).

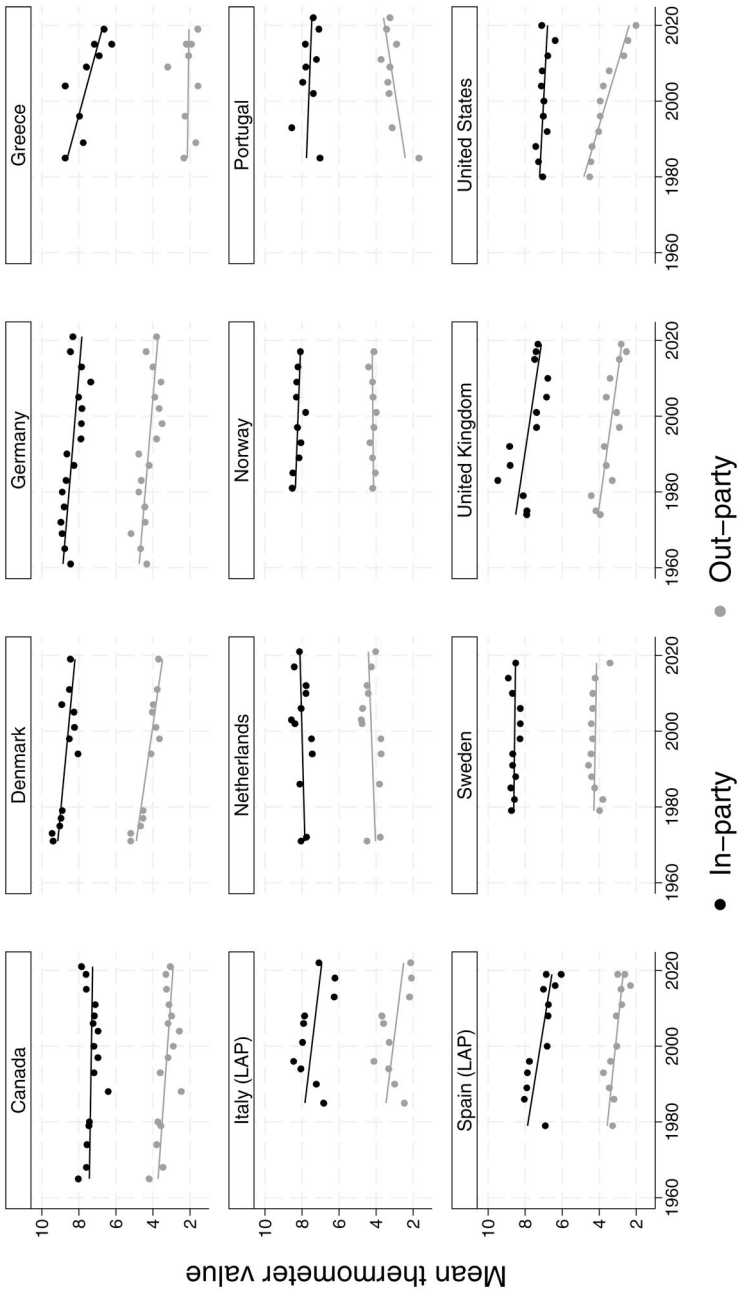

Figure 1. Mean thermometer values for in-party and out-parties. In Italy and Spain, scores are calculated based on leader (LAP) rather than party (PAP) thermometer evaluations.

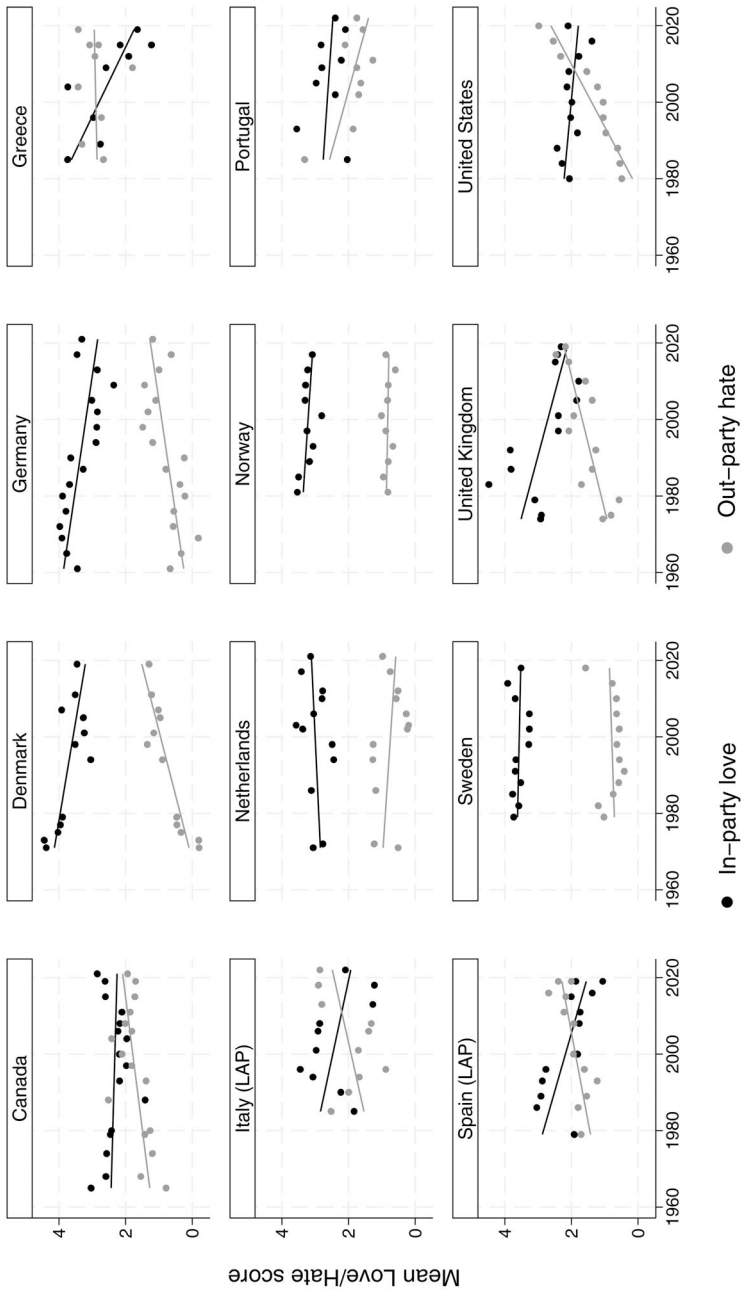

Figure 2. In-party love and out-party hate in twelve Western democracies. In Italy and Spain, scores are calculated based on leader (LAP) rather than party (PAP) thermometer evaluations.

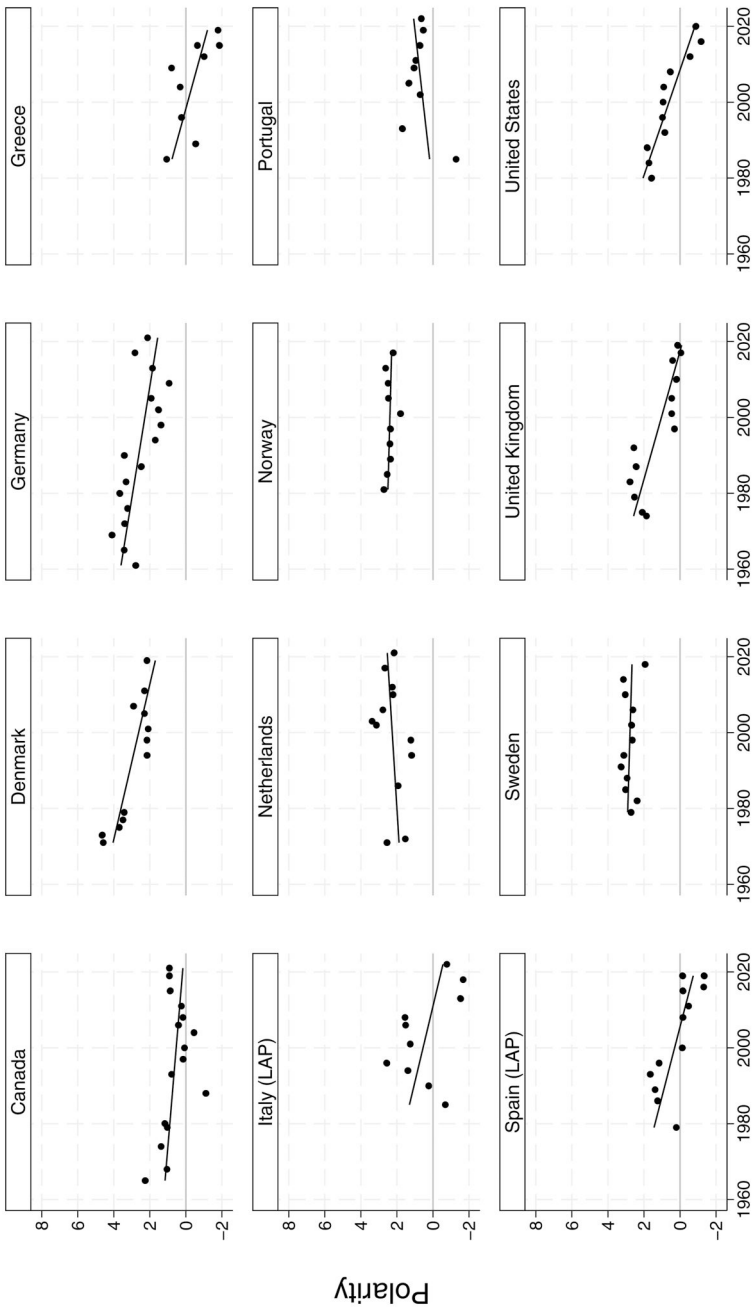

Figure 3. The changing polarity of affect in twelve Western democracies. Polarity of affect is the difference between in-party love and out-party hate. Positive values reflect greater in-group love than out-group hate, and negative values reflect greater out-group hate than in-group love. In Italy and Spain, scores are calculated based on leader (LAP) rather than party (PAP) thermometer evaluations.

importance of out-party hate vis-à-vis in-party love in a large majority of the countries of the sample. In recent years, values of out-party hate tend to approach values of in-party love—this is particularly evident in Canada, Denmark, Germany, and the United Kingdom. Moreover, in countries like Greece, Italy, Spain, and the United States, out-party hate has actually become a stronger force than in-party love.

In a final step, we report the algebraic difference between in-party love and out-party hate, a measure developed by Finkel et al. (2020) to reflect the overall polarity of affect in a political system. Figure 3 shows a pattern toward increasing negativity of affective polarization across ten of the twelve countries. The regression slope reaches conventional levels of statistical significance in Denmark, Germany, Greece, Spain, the United Kingdom, and the United States (see Supplementary Material table S3).

Importantly, we can observe that recent elections across countries such as Canada, Greece, Italy, Spain, the United Kingdom, and the United States have gone beyond the tipping point in which the weight of out-party hate trumps in-party love, registering negative values. Even in a country like Sweden, which reports relatively high and stable patterns on this measure, the latest election clearly ranks among the lowest value of the time series.

Conclusions

With a few exceptions, our findings show a generalized decline of out-party evaluations on the thermometer score and a growing prevalence of out-party hate over in-party love over time. While citizens may not be more polarized than before in most Western democracies (Garzia, Ferreira da Silva, and Maye 2023; Boxell, Gentzkow, and Shapiro 2024), we observe that contemporary affective polarization tends to be more heavily characterized by a disproportionate weight of out-group dislike. Moreover, in recent elections across several countries, citizens now express, on average, stronger negative attitudes toward the out-party than positive attitudes toward the in-party.

By exclusively capturing the length of affective distances between in- and out-parties, previous work has remained oblivious to the nature of the affect underlying such distance. While polarization levels may be high/low, the extent to which such polarization is characterized by a disproportionate degree of affect/disaffect may entail distinct sociopolitical implications. Our findings suggest the complementarity of considering the relative weight of in- and out-party affect in interpreting affective polarization in multiparty systems, and put in perspective previous normative interpretations of the longitudinal dynamics of affective polarization in Western democracies.

Supplementary Material

Supplementary Material may be found in the online version of this article: https://doi.org/10.1093/poq/nfaf013.

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Data Availability

Replication data and documentation are available at https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/5TDXIA.

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